

Asian American Emotional Resonance and Cross-Cultural Memory in *In the Mood for Love*

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Asian American identities are shaped by not one clear cultural lineage, but an ongoing negotiation and overlap between multiple linguistic, emotional, and historical worlds. Layered contexts in the Asian American experience can cultivate individualistically unique complex emotional styles that also represent shared themes, such as indirection, restraint, and self-management (Lowe 64–66). Because of broad complexity and diversity within and among Asian American communities, their responses to social representation are rarely uniform. In modern times, representation of Asian Americans and their experiences in media, particularly in film, has increased in exposure and criticism. For instance, *Crazy Rich Asians* (2018) offered Asian Americans racial and cultural visibility, but faced widespread critique for its glossy and exaggerated emotional palette, which felt largely incongruent to their lived experiences (Koh 2; Liu 1; Wang 2). In contrast, Wong Kar-wai's *In the Mood for Love* (2000), which follows two neighbors as they form an intimate bond after discovering their spouses are having an affair, is set entirely in 1950s–1960s Hong Kong and features no Asian American characters. Despite no direct national representation nor clearly Asian American-associated themes, the film has elicited high popularity and profound feelings of recognition and nostalgia among Asian American viewers. Critics describe it as capturing their felt but unspoken emotions that they rarely saw onscreen, particularly longing triggered by memory, personal or cultural, and desire for emotional connection (Choy 218; He 2). Contrasting reception between the two films among Asian American audiences suggests that emotional resonance may emerge not primarily from racial representation, but from the deeper aesthetic and sensory textures of a film.

Music is a powerful texture through which media can connect emotionally with the consumer. In contrast to language, music can travel across cultural

and generational borders more freely, communicating profound ideas such as memory, nostalgia, and mood without explicit explanation (Wong, 23–25). Thus, music can express the emotional tone of a scene without the characters needing to say anything aloud. *In the Mood for Love* consistently employs this. Rather than drawing on traditional or explicitly “Asian-coded” music, Wong Kar-Wai put together a hybrid soundtrack consisting only of Cantonese oldies, orchestral waltzes, and Spanish-language boleros performed by Nat King Cole (Choo 2). Scholars have described *In the Mood for Love*'s sonic environment as a “model of hybridity” that creates a unique emotional landscape through a transnational mixture of music (Bettinson 31–32). *In the Mood for Love* resonates powerfully with many Asian American viewers because Wong Kar-Wai constructs a relatable emotional world through this hybrid soundtrack that uses sound to mirror patterns of restraint, longing, and in-between feelings that shape Asian diasporic life.

Nat King Cole's Spanish boleros are one of the key sonic languages in the film that shapes feelings that are heard and resonated with by many Asian American viewers. The boleros have been deeply embedded in Asian listening cultures intergenerationally and have sonic qualities that trigger cultural memory, such as vocal restraint, rhythmic hesitation, and linguistic struggles. These characteristics allow the boleros to act like an interior emotional register that operates in deliberate contrast to the film's other musical registers of outward control. These musical layers mirror the emotional layers of the Asian American diasporic experience often characterized by inward vulnerability and outward restraint. *In the Mood for Love*'s emotional power for Asian American audiences arises not from visual or national representation alone, but from a soundtrack that shares diasporic feeling and memory. These dynamics can be understood by tracing how Latin music, particularly Nat King Cole's

boleros contextualized by his identity, is embedded in intergenerational Asian listening cultures, examining how Wong Kar-Wai uses the boleros in the film's emotional scenes and comparing them with another significant film score, and turning to contemporary Asian American reception to show how the film and its music is experienced across the diaspora.

Although Spanish-language boleros might initially seem out of place in a Hong Kong romance film spoken entirely in Shanghaiese and Cantonese, Spanish music is historically and culturally embedded in the Asian soundscape. Latin American music circulated widely across Asia, particularly East and Southeast Asia, in the 1950s–1960s. As jazz had already secured its spot in Asia, Latin jazz grew quickly among Asian musicians that appreciated the high technical skill associated with it. Latin jazz artists toured across East Asia in the mid-1900s, performing well-attended concerts at prestigious venues; Latin music was regularly played on the radio; entire domestic orchestras were formed to perform Latin renditions, even receiving an award from Fidel Castro (Tinajero 140). Latin music was adapted deeply into Asian life; even into the early 2000s, Japanese journalists said that the Japanese “felt [Latin music] all their lives” (Tinajero 158). Asian listeners absorbed Latin music not linguistically, but in memory and emotion, and Latin sounds became “familiar, romantic, yet exotic” (Breath of Life 1). Though Tinajero focuses on Latin music in Japan, these patterns of popularity were not unique to Japan; Latin music was embedded across many other Asian countries such as Korea, the Philippines, and China. For migrants living away from Asia, music, particularly Latin boleros and related genres, became a source of emotional connotations and social nostalgia.

Nat King Cole was one widely recognized figure in the transnational musical environment. In his 1963 month-long tour across East Asia, Cole expressed his surprise that Asians had “been playing [his] records for years” and his sense of “kinship” coming from seeing how deeply his songs had permeated the Asian soundscape (Stars and Stripes 1). In South Korea for example, Cole was invited to host his concert at the famous Seoul Municipal Auditorium; high-powered executives, businessmen, and entertainers hosted receptions for him, indicating that Nat King Cole was highly known and anticipated rather than a sporadic foreign appearance (Stars and Stripes 1). Cole's Spanish-language albums had been widely imported, broadcast on local radio, and absorbed into household listening across the region, which meant

that his boleros functioned as familiar emotional texts for Asian audiences well before the era depicted in *In the Mood for Love*.

Wong Kar-Wai grew up inside this sonic world in Asia. Across multiple interviews, he recalled hearing Nat King Cole's Spanish songs on his mother's radio throughout his childhood, and he chose the same original recordings for *In the Mood for Love* because they directly captured the “layer of longing” and “exoticism” that was present in Hong Kong in the 1960s through this music (Tsu Wei 98; Wigley 4). In addition to Nat King Cole's specific Spanish songs, Cole's identity as a Black American also connected with Asian culture and history. In the mid-1900s, Black and Asian musical communities recognized emotional and political parallels in each others' experiences as minorities or abused groups; these groups referred to each other as “Oriental brothers” and “yellow negroes” and perceived Black musical expression as a “bridge” across other racial and cultural differences (Atkins 94). Through these nuanced personal and cultural lenses, Wong Kar-Wai's inclusion of Cole in *In the Mood for Love*'s soundtrack can be recognized to not simply be because of Cole's popularity, but also because Cole was an important part of transnational history and memory for Asian American families.

Understanding Nat King Cole's historical presence in Asia helps to clarify the prominence of his songs in Wong Kar-Wai's film as not something arbitrary or foreign, but as something emotionally familiar and culturally significant. Although *In the Mood for Love* includes other music, the Nat King Cole songs stand out for combining Spanish lyrics, Western orchestral accompaniment, and Cole's unique vocal qualities, which creates a unique sound for film characters' often unspoken emotions. Wong includes three of Cole's songs in the film, “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás,” “Aquellos Ojos Verdes,” and “Te Quiero Dijiste,” and effectively brings them back repeatedly to emotionally accentuate moments of longing and hesitation in the plot.

A key reason Cole's boleros feel emotionally resonant is the experience of partial linguistic comprehension that they produce. Cole's three songs are entirely in Spanish, which most Asian viewers of *In the Mood for Love* did not understand; thus, viewers had to understand the songs through subtler cues like tone and phrasing, rather than literal meaning (Quintero 1). This dynamic mirrors how emotional communication often functions within Asian American families, where feelings are often opaque to others and conveyed indirectly through gestures, tones, and

implications, rather than explicit statements (Lowe 79). The fact that the boleros are literally unintelligible becomes an emotional structure in itself for Asian Americans.

Moreover, Cole's accented Spanish reinforces this quality of opaque communication and linguistic in-betweenness. When he recorded the piece, Cole did not speak Spanish fluently; he had to memorize phonetics in order to sing the songs at all. Thus, his Spanish in the film has a thick accent (Cantor-Navas 1). At moments such as 0:45–1:02 in “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás,” he consistently elongates and mispronounces vowels, singing “PAYNE-san-do” for *pensando*, or “cuan-DOW” for *cuando*. This constant and exaggerated mispronunciation produces a sound of almost-fluency throughout the song to both Spanish and non-Spanish speakers. This linguistic in-betweenness may feel deeply familiar to Asian American immigrants who grew up around mixed-language environments with varying proficiency and understanding. Through this shared linguistic challenge, Cole's boleros in the film create a space that resonates with the cultural experiences that many Asian Americans have faced in their families.

The musical structure of “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás” amplifies the liminality and hesitation throughout the film. The song follows a bolero 4/4 rhythm, where the first beat is emphasized and the rest are moved through quickly; Cole stretches the first syllable of many phrases (which further emphasizes his thick American accent) and hurries through the rest of the bar to catch the next downbeat. This literally creates a rhythmic push and pull, which produces a feeling of hesitation, where the music constantly steps forwards and backwards. Though he hurries through measures, Cole sometimes misses the downbeat in more emotionally charged moments of the song; for example, his entrance on “días” (0:41) lands just after the drum gives the downbeat, giving a sense of reluctance to assert back into the melody. Then, repetition works to accentuate the suspense. Throughout the song, Cole circles through short repeated phrases like “quizás, quizás, quizás” (0:22–0:25; 0:41–0:43), “pensando, pensando, pensando” (0:50–0:53), and “hasta cuándo, hasta cuándo, hasta cuándo” (1:04–1:07) with limited other lyrics. Near the end, he repeats “quizás” nine times, with the last phrase twice as slow, allowing the music to hover in a suspended emotional state rather than move toward resolution. The musical qualities of Cole's Spanish boleros map closely onto emotional patterns that many Asian Americans describe, such as restraint,

hesitation, and the pressure to maintain composure. These habits may be particularly present among Asian Americans because they learn to hold parts of themselves back, especially when communicating verbally with others, in order to meet expectations of assimilation as the model minority while preserving ties to cultural identity and individualism (Cheng 56). For Asian Americans, “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás” is a song that can sonically embody lived experience of being caught in between expression and containment that speaks to Asian diasporic experience.

The two other boleros used in the film, “Aquellos Ojos Verdes” and “Te Quiero Dijiste,” contribute other emotional textures while reinforcing similar themes of inbetweenness, using hesitation through rhythm, displacement through accented Spanish, and suspension through repetition. “Te Quiero Dijiste” sounds slightly more intimate than “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás” due to a softer volume and slower tempo. This quality deepens the feeling of hesitant warmth or romance that Asian Americans may resonate with, especially during scenes such as the protagonists' first ‘date’ while pretending to reenact their spouses' affair (00:30:45–00:31:19). Then, “Aquellos Ojos Verdes” uses fuller string orchestration to accompany more intense romantic moments, such as the second date in which the affair participants begin to more outwardly flirt with each other (00:33:00–00:35:00). Asian Americans may resonate with how these songs communicate salient stages in the plot through less explicit musical qualities, a skill that mirrors how Asian Americans need to understand tone and unspoken gestures when communicating within their culture.

In the film, a demonstration of this unspoken communication happens when the female lead spontaneously calls the male lead after they broke up (1:24:00–1:24:53). “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás” begins the moment that the male lead answers the phone, and the female lead remains completely silent, lowering the phone to her chest for nearly thirty seconds while the song continues to play. The step forward and back rhythm and behind-the-beat phrasing mirrors the female lead's emotional state while reaching out, being unable to push forward and speak, and retreating back into solitude and emotional safety. The music ends the moment that the female lead reaches for her shoes, which is a recurring symbol of the emotional affair throughout the film, only to pull back her hand. The pair of musical hesitation and emotional vulnerability may resonate deeply with Asian American viewers because of the complex dynamic of wanting connection with others, feeling pressure to withhold

emotion and individuality, and navigating indirect communication in interpersonal relationships. The song is not a backtrack, but an emotional landscape musically narrating the film that Asian Americans can recognize and resonate with.

While Nat King Cole's three boleros articulate the emotional and vulnerable inner world of the characters, other works in the soundtrack serve different purposes. Shigeru Umebayashi's "Yumeji's Theme" is another of the most prominent works in the film, and highlights the characters' external composure and social performance. "Yumeji's Theme" plays during scenes where the leads move silently through their daily routines. In particular, "Yumeji's Theme" always plays during scenes in the beginning of the movie where the leads pass each other in a narrow alleyway outside a noodle stall with almost no dialogue or interaction, sometimes a single gesture. Wong Kar-Wai edits these repeated encounters into a montage (00:14:30–00:17:10). The unbreaking and strict rhythm in "Yumeji's Theme" creates a sense of regularity; each phrase always returns cyclically to either the same pitch or at most a whole step below where it started, pushing the sense of regularity, discipline, and self-management. The music captures how, in the alleyway, the characters outwardly contain their inner emotions and desires for the other person. This restraint may resonate with Asian American viewers, who see one of their major roles in society as the model minority, which requires outward calm despite stressful situations, courtesy to others, and emotional containment.

The role of "Yumeji's Theme" becomes clear when the pattern finally breaks. In the last noodle-stall alleyway scene, the music begins as normal as the two follow their familiar routines. However, at the exact moment that they appear together in the same frame and begin speaking to each other for the first time in this setting, the music stops abruptly (00:24:30–00:26:07). This harsh silence marks a significant emotional shift in which the characters could not resist their desires, broke the rules, and began their romantic affair. Viewers who are sensitive to rules and are familiar with emotional shifts may find this emotional discordance, made explicit through musical dynamics, especially striking. Though "Yumeji's Theme" does not carry inherited cultural memory like Cole's boleros, the song works in other ways to represent the emotional landscape and resonate with Asian Americans in the audience. "Yumeji's Theme" and "Quizás, Quizás, Quizás" serve complementary functions that highlight the emotional layers that Asian

Americans experience. The parallel musical structure, where the former speaks for the managed exterior and the latter speaks for unspoken interior, mirrors Asian Americans' emotional tension between what one is allowed to show and what one feels.

This emotional contrast between the two works is accentuated when considering their different origins. "Yumeji's Theme" is now iconic, but was engineered by Wong and a collaborating composer specifically for *In the Mood for Love*. Wong Kar-Wai said that he was striving for the underlying string motif to sound like a "heartbeat," having composed the work early and to use in guiding the rhythm of scenes that he filmed afterwards (Wigley 2). He later explained that the theme was inspired by another Asian film, but was heavily redesigned and perfected for the purposes of *In the Mood for Love*, seamlessly representing the characters' predictability and emotional performance in the movie (Tsu Wei 97–98). In contrast, Nat King Cole's boleros entered the film with the weight of lived cultural memory. Wong inserted Cole's recordings from 1958 unaltered into his 2000 film, preserving the exact sounds that circulated across Asian radios, including his own family's. Cole's songs introduce emotional texture that was not engineered for the film but rather inherited from the past; with this, the film allows Asian Americans to recall emotional and cultural associations that they formed through multilingual and transnational listening before watching the movie. For Asian viewers, this difference may enforce further associations of "Yumeji's Theme" with feelings of sterility and discipline that are engineered within the film; Cole's boleros elicit nostalgic emotions, transcending the film through memory. By situating these two genres against each other repeatedly throughout the film, Wong Kar-Wai highlights how he does not only rely on national or cultural representation to create relatability. Rather, Wong creates an emotional window through sound, recalling Asian Americans' experiences with restraint and longing that shape their everyday emotional dynamics. The film music creates an emotional language that many members of the Asian American audience can resonate with.

Personal accounts from contemporary Asian American viewers corroborate this strong emotional connection with and uncertainty about *In the Mood for Love*, indicating that the interplay of restraint and musical memory continues to resonate across communities and generations. For example, Asian American viewers on social media describe their emotional connection to Cole's boleros in *In the Mood for Love*, even if they cannot clearly articulate why it

elicits nostalgia. One commenter notes that the music “captures human feelings to great fidelity... evoking longing, regret, tension, and conflict” (TikTok, 2025); another writes that it “leaves you wondering how close one is yet so far,” and another observes that “the score makes you really ‘feel’ what the movie is showing” (Reddit, 2020). These responses echo the musical qualities of “Quizás, Quizás, Quizás” that promote emotional connection, such as emotional hesitation, circling without resolution, and the tension between desire and restraint. Viewers are responding not necessarily to lyrical meaning or cultural origin but to the feeling of suspended emotion and affective memory that mirrors how they learned to hold in their feelings. At the same time, responses are mixed. Some Asian Americans comment that their Asian families “never cared for this music” (Reddit, 2023), while others say they “do not get the hype” and “cannot stand it” (TikTok, 2025). This variability shows how there is no singular Asian American experience. The film and its soundtrack do not resonate universally across the full spectrum of Asian American experience, but its affective qualities are recognizable and felt by many others who share cultural values and experiences.

Tracing the history of Latin and Black music across Asian soundscapes, examining how boleros and orchestrations were used in *In the Mood for Love*, and understanding how the film connected emotionally with Asian American audience members shows how the film’s music gives a tangible form to patterns of emotions and livelihood that many Asian American viewers experience every day: hesitation, discipline, nostalgia, and indirectness. The soundtrack of the film is not only an expressive device for the characters within the film, but also a model for how Asian American viewers experience the film and read emotion at a larger scale through tone, implication, and unspoken gestures. The historical facet of Nat King Cole adds a layer of resonance and hybridity that connects Asian American listeners to a transnational musical past they may not have lived firsthand but feel through cultural and intergenerational memory. Nuances in *In the Mood for Love*’s soundtrack that are not present in other films such as *Crazy Rich Asians* may explain the discrepancy with which Asian Americans emotionally receive different works. *Crazy Rich Asians* prioritized objective on-screen representation; although *Crazy Rich Asians* attempted to incorporate musical, cultural, and historical tools to connect with Asian Americans, the film did not accomplish it to the same extent as Wong Kar-Wai’s soundtrack, which elicits visceral reactions to emotional complexity and relatability.

Wong Kar-Wai’s soundtrack demonstrates that Asian American representation and emotional resonance are not always visually communicated or explicitly Asian American. Asian American history and music are built by more than Asian sounds and Asian people. Rather, the Asian American landscape, inherently valuing inbetweenness and hybridity, is built at a transnational and intercultural level that transcends borders of ethnicity and nationality.

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